

And sure enough, Sift left it all behind like a bad dream. At the very start of the season on February 3, she struck gold at the National Games. A week later, she topped two selection trials. Incidentally, her T2 qualification score of 595 would have seen her become the first to qualify for the final in Paris 2024.

Quite unsurprisingly, she was the Indian team's first pick for the season-opening ISSF World Cup in Argentina. The fact that Sift's first international event straight after the Olympics was being held at the Tiro Federal Argentino de Buenos Aires, a range that hadn't hosted a World Cup before, added further drama. No one knew what to expect.

The sighters done away with, Sift picked up where she left off in Delhi, even registering a perfect 100 in the second round of Kneeling. The qualification concluded without a hitch and Sift's 590 secured her pole position ahead of the final. The first signs of trouble bobbed up when

nature decided to play spoilsport.

"In India, we start competitions by 8:30-9 am. Here we started at 2:30 pm. The temperature and

weather conditions are very different [according to historical data on Weather Underground, in Buenos Aires it was 16.1 degrees Celsius at that point in time, while in New Delhi the lowest recorded temperature on the same day was 21.1 degrees]. When we started our match, it was already extremely windy and cold. In the final, since it was already approaching sunset, the wind direction was changing and even the intensity was variable."

Sift, clearly affected, couldn't land a single shot inside the 10-ring in her first series of five shots. Having led through the qualification, she had suddenly dropped to last. And there was a 2.5-point difference between her and then seventh-placed Wang Zifei. When Kneeling finished, everyone except Sift was well inside the 150s. Sift's score read 147.2.

A collective gasp ran through as Parisian flashbacks came back to the

crowd. Sift, however, blessed with a mature head on young shoulders, didn't freeze.

"I can't give up hope,' I thought. And one good thing about 3P is that even if one of your positions is ruined, you have two more to recover in. This wasn't the first time I was doing badly in Kneeling. It was very bad, yes, but nothing I had not been through."

In Prone, she fared comparatively better, but she was still at the bottom of the pile. The gap to seventh place, though, had come down to 0.2. "By the time we started Standing, it had started to go dark. I faced a lot of problems, but knew I had to shoot well here to recover my rankings," Sift says.

Standing has always been her favourite position, but earlier that day in the qualification, Sift had scored the lowest in it. But that didn't matter as Sift started Standing — also the elimination round — with a bang. She shot 52.3 and 51.2 in the first two series, which not only saw her dodge the axe but also propelled her to the very top of the leaderboard.

And once she had broken free from the pack, there was no looking back. She kept widening the gap at the top to eventually claim the gold medal with a score of 458.6.

Germany's Anita Mangold won silver with 455.3. Interestingly, Sift had been a massive 7.2 points behind Anita after Kneeling!

She would later confess she had help. "I'd say it was God who helped me bridge the gap," she says.

Sift did fall short of the final spot in the subsequent Peru World Cup by one point, but she has a shot at becoming the first Indian woman to win the World Championship gold in November. "I will try my best is all I can say. It will be in Cairo, where it will be windy. I have been there. It will be at the end of the year, so there is a lot of time left. Before that, we will have the Asian Championship as well," Sift says, her brows furrowed and gaze unwavering.

And there it was — the very real image of the quintessential champion shooter.

« Sift shares her thoughts on the introduction of a 'Standing only' 50m 3 Positions final for the next Olympics. It will be a little bit interesting. I don't know many details, though, be it the number of shots we will be taking or the time we will be getting. Now, in Standing, we have 50 seconds for a single shot. But I think this will be good for the Indians because all our athletes have a very good [record in] 'Standing'. It is a favourable position for us. It is going to help us, but we never know, because now all the athletes — even foreigners — will also work on a single position. It is a new thing. We are excited to find out how challenging it will be. We haven't discussed [the training regime] yet. The qualification will be the same, though. So, we will have to go through all three positions, and do well in all of them. Once the [detailed] rules come, only then will we be able to draw out a strategy on how to work on this new change »